Police, from where he eventually retired as an Additional Director General (ADG). The senior subaltern was Lt NPS Hira, who had the onerous job of keeping us under control. The other officers present in the unit then were Capt Rudra Sen Sindhu and Capt BK Sharma. BK Sharma rose to the rank of Major General and is currently the director general, United Service Institution (USI) of India, a Delhi-based think-tank. Sindhu, a short service commission (SSC) officer left the Army much to our dismay on completion of his five-year tour and runs a successful business out of Gurgaon.

Veena and I had been corresponding regularly since my IMA days. Even after commissioning, I was spending much of my leave in Delhi. We were now going 'steady' for a long time and decided to get married. It is a custom in the Army to ask the CO's permission to get married through a formal application, which I wrote out by hand, dated 1 April 1983. By then, Col NM Verma had taken over the reins of the unit and I wasn't exactly in his good books. The timing of the request made him believe that I was playing an elaborate April Fool's joke, which indeed had been my intention. The unit was to move to field later that year, so we decided to get married on 30 June, a date that was decided arbitrarily by me. I thought it would be a good idea to start the training year, which commences 1 July onwards, with a bang. I left Bikaner for my wedding on two months' annual leave and rejoined only at the new location in the Chhamb Jaurian sector of J & K, which had been the scene of some fierce fighting in the 1971 war.

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Budhwal

The Battalion HQ was in a nondescript village called Budhwal, surrounded by paddy and mustard fields. We were part of